for Akbar's mother, Hamida, to arrive for a more touching scene of reunion. Hamida came to Kabul with the spring, riding up from Qandahar as 'violets raised their head from the stream's lip'.[31] When she reached, Humayun arranged a little game: he brought Akbar into the harem, carrying the three-year-old on his shoulders. When father and son were seated, side by side, the ladies streamed in and arranged themselves before the pair. Gulbadan would have been among them, and Akbar's many jealous mamas, and also, perhaps, Askari's wife, Sultan Begum, who had taken such loving care of the prince in Qandahar. Also among them was Hamida, deliberately unmarked in any way. Once the stage was set, Humayun told his son to find his mother – at which, the story goes, Akbar toddled straight into Hamida's lap. A painting of the scene shows a child with a determined chin falling into his mother's lap; what catches the eye, however, is the tenderness of the glance between Hamida and Humayun.[32] So much might have filled a look in that moment: the delight of parents in their progeny, the unspoken understanding of lovers in public, the quiet relief of an emperor and his queen with a city to rule, finally.

A 'shout arose', writes Abul Fazl, and its call for celebration can be heard across the centuries. As immediate cause, it was time for Akbar's circumcision; or, as Abul Fazl insists on putting it, 'for pruning the sapling of the divine garden'.[33] Circumcision was, and remains, a significant event in families across cultures and terrains, but circumcision alone cannot explain the sheer extravagance of the party. It went on for days – seventeen by one account – the decoration of the city's bazaars and gardens 'exceeds description'; the chieftains held wrestling competitions, received fiefs and titles and robes of honour, basking in 'the light of favour'.[34] There was feasting and giving of alms and granting of amnesty – to, amongst others, that fickle cousin Yadgar Nasir. 'Small and great', all were invited – 'high and low', all were favoured.[35] Such festivities were not to mark a milestone in Akbar's life alone, but also in his father's. After a three-year absence, Humayun wanted 'to restore his contacts with the nobility',[36] to let them know they had a new ruler to celebrate.

Many of them, while quaffing their drinks and cheering their prodigal padishah, may have wondered how long Humayun's new rule would last. There was, after all, the niggling fact that Kabul didn't really belong to him;